

GLOSSARY

Terms defined elsewhere in the glossary are in *italics*.

abolitionism

Advocacy of the abolition of slavery.

absolutism

A theory of the state where a country's ruler or government is regarded as possessing an **absolute authority**: that is, an authority that is not dependent on the consent of the people being governed.

accession

The point at which a monarch begins his or her reign.

agrarian

Relating to land and its cultivation. The term **agrarianism** relates to political movements aimed at promoting the interests of agriculture and rural life.

allies/Allied

People or countries working together. In World War I and World War II, the Allies or Allied forces were the countries fighting against Germany.

anarchy

In its original meaning, absence of government; also used for a condition of public disorder. Politically, **anarchism** is a movement or ideology that believes in the abolition of government as an ideal for society.

anticlericalism

Opposition to the influence of churches and other religious organizations in society. In some (mainly *Catholic*) countries such as France, Spain, and Italy it has been an important political force.

anti-Semitism

Antagonism and hostility toward Jewish people.

apartheid

The policy of racial *segregation* formerly followed in the Republic of South Africa, or policies elsewhere that resemble this.

armistice

A truce or cessation of hostilities.

authoritarian

Term applied to leaders or governments who exercise power with little or no regard for *democracy* or other constraints.

autocracy

A form of political rule where all power is concentrated in one person (the **autocrat**). Unlike the similar term *dictator*, the word autocrat is often applied to a powerful king or emperor.

Axis

The alliance between Germany and Italy (and later Japan) before and during World War II; also these countries considered collectively (Axis forces or Axis domination).

bilateral

Involving two governments (or other organizations), especially with reference to treaties and agreements. Compare *multilateral*.

bloc

A group of countries that act together in matters of international relations.

bourgeoisie

Originally a member of the French middle classes, now often used disparagingly for a supporter of the capitalist system (see *capitalism*), or simply for a person with conventional views. In *Marxist* theory, the **bourgeoisie** are the class of capitalists.

buffer state

A smaller country lying between two more powerful rival countries. The presence of a buffer state is considered useful in decreasing tension between the rival countries.

Byzantine Empire

The mainly Greek-speaking Christian Empire that was a continuation of the eastern Roman Empire and lasted for around 1,000 years, until its conquest by the Ottoman Turks in 1453.

Caliphate

In Islamic (see *Islam*) culture this is a political/religious institution in which a chosen individual, the **caliph**, is regarded as a successor to the Prophet Muhammad, and thus able to confer political legitimacy on individual rulers across the Islamic world. Once powerful rulers themselves, caliphs later became mainly figureheads, although the Ottoman rulers of Turkey continued to claim the title until the 20th century.

Calvinism

A strict form of Protestantism named after the 16th-century religious reformer John Calvin. **Calvinist churches** are usually *Presbyterian* in organization.

capitalism

A way of organizing society that favors the activity of **capitalists**: private individuals or organizations who accumulate wealth (**capital**), especially in the form of the buildings and equipment that are necessary to produce goods and services. These businesses generate employment, while also providing profits for the capitalists.

Catholic

A term that originally meant inclusive or all-embracing, so that the **Catholic Church** originally meant the whole of the Christian Church. After various splits over the centuries, the Catholic Church is now the organization of churches that owes its allegiance to the pope in Rome, thus it is also called the Roman Catholic Church.

charter

A written grant of rights or similar legal document.

city-state

A self-governing, independent city.

classical/Classical

Relating to the civilizations of ancient Greece and Rome and their achievements (the **Classical Period**) or to later artistic and cultural movements that emulated the values of this period. The term classical can also be applied to the high point of any civilization or culture, and can be used with other shades of meaning, such as "possessing timeless value."

client state

A country that is dependent on another larger country for trade, protection, etc.

coalition

A formal arrangement in which two or more different groups agree to act together, such as when different political parties come together to form a government.

Cold War

The period of hostility between the West and the communist countries dominated by the former USSR. The Cold War lasted from shortly after World War II until the collapse of *communism* in Eastern Europe in 1989.

collective

Organized in common; taken together as a whole.

colonialism

The practice and policy of acquiring foreign colonies, often with the implication that this involves cultural domination and exploitation.

commonwealth/Commonwealth

The term commonwealth originally meant "the common good." With an initial capital, Commonwealth refers either to the government of Britain in the years following the execution of Charles I, or to the (British) Commonwealth of Nations, the association set up to maintain links between countries of the former British Empire. The word also occurs in the full official names of several countries and US states.

commune

A community of people who aim at sharing everything in common.

communism

[1] Any society based on the principles of mutual help, in which property is not owned by individuals, but is held in common. [2] More specifically, political movements or governments inspired by or claiming to act in the name of the political and philosophical doctrines of Karl Marx (see *Marxist*).

Congress

In the US Constitution, the body forming the legislative arm of the federal government (see *federal system*). It comprises two elected assemblies, the House of Representatives (or Lower House) and the Senate (or Upper House).

conservative/Conservative

Various social and political meanings, including: caution in accepting change; respect for traditional values and authority; support for free-market *capitalism* and opposition to government intervention; membership of a particular political party, such as the Conservative Party in the United Kingdom.

consul

One of the two highest officials in the Roman republic, who each held power for only one year.

Counter-Reformation

The period of revival in the *Catholic Church* following the Protestant *Reformation*, involving both internal reforms and active opposition to *Protestantism*.

coup

Short for coup d'état, the sudden illegal seizing of power by a small group.

Crusades

Military expeditions organized by the papacy in the *Medieval period*, initially with the goal of gaining control of the "Holy Land" (Palestine) from Islamic powers (see *Islam*).

czar

The title of the former emperors of Russia. A female czar, or a czar's wife, is a **czarina**.

Danegeld

A tax raised in Anglo-Saxon England to pay off and defend against Danish invaders. It later became a general land tax.

decimal system (army)

The principle of organization of Genghis Khan's Mongol army, with a hierarchy of military units that contained between 10 and 10,000 men.